

Wedding Woes

An NRI's take on the Indian arranged marriage system



MARRYING ANITA: A QUEST FOR LOVE IN THE NEW INDIA

by ANITA JAIN

Bloomsbury

Price: £12.99; Pages: 307

■ By Sonya Dutta Choudhury

Anita Jain has all the right credentials. She's a singleton journalist, and has travelled the world. Her articles, including the much-discussed "Is arranged marriage any worse than the Craigslist?", make amusing reading. So why is *Marrying Anita* such a drag? Certainly the book would, with its updates on the men in her life, make for a great blog. There's no dearth of masala—it's an-NRI-girl-comes-to-Delhi-to-see-a-good-husband story. There are the drunken nights speeding down Gurgaon highways; there's even a trip to the Himalayas with three guys in a car with no air-conditioning. Then there are flashback stories of childhood visits to India involving horrific loos and being groped by an unidentified cousin.

Jain writes with disarming frankness. Why, then, does the book not work for me? Maybe I'm not singleton enough or even NRI enough. Certainly, I don't, at least in Jain's book, have the right attitude. An attitude which she exhibits with evangelistic enthusiasm. At an arranged marriage meeting, she makes sure her father serves the tea—"For added effect, later in the conversation, I ask my father to get me a glass of water. Papa rises from his seat dutifully and scurries to the kitchen, returning with the water." No prizes for guessing who will scurry away next. The other suitors seem to share similar fates. They are all—like Nair, the electric guitarist and Shekhar, the unemployed Bihari man—a series of well-written profiles. There's no one you can really root for. Even Aristu, the pilot who leaves Anita "pock-marked with desire" stays lifeless. All of which leave me, like the in-between Anita and her endless string of boyfriends—quite bored, wondering why I am doing this and in the end, wholly unengaged. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The 3 Mistakes of My Life	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa
2. (2)	A Prisoner of Birth	Jeffrey Archer	Pan Macmillan
3. (3)	Brida	Paulo Coelho	HarperCollins
4. (4)	Unaccustomed Earth	Jhumpa Lahiri	Random House
5. (-)	Sea of Poppies	Amitav Ghosh	Penguin

NON-FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (-)	The Last Lecture	Randy Pausch & Jeffrey Zaslow	Hodder & Stoughton
3. (-)	Three Cups of Tea	David Oliver Relin	Penguin
4. (3)	The Monk Who Sold His Ferrari	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico
5. (9)	Who Will Cry When You Die?	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (9)	The Enchantress of Florence	Salman Rushdie	Jonathan Cape
10. (12)	Shantaram	Gregory David Roberts	Penguin
13. (-)	A Case of Exploding Mangoes	Mohammed Hanif	Random House
14. (16)	The Japanese Wife	Kunal Basu	HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (2)	Superstar India: From Incredible to Unstoppable	Shobhaa De	Penguin
7. (8)	The Elephant, the Tiger and the Cell Phone	Shashi Tharoor	Penguin
9. (7)	Entry from Backside Only	Binoo K. John	Penguin
11. (19)	My Country, My Life	L.K. Advani	Rupa
13. (-)	Maximum City: Bombay Lost and Found	Suketu Mehta	Penguin

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead